

| By Arvind Chhabra |

Patiala's Manmeet Singh, 24, lost his father to alcohol. That, however, did not deter this only son from taking to drugs. It took just a scolding from his mother about "not being serious" about his career to cross over to where his friends had already arrived by then. The family had land and money, so college life was all about friends, parties, girls and drinking binges. Moving on to smack was then only incidental. What was initially achievable for Rs 100 soon needed Rs 600 and a full gram of the contraband. "Initially I could manage it from home. Then I began to borrow, beg and steal. Soon I was in debt," says Manmeet. One day he fraudulently got his mother's signature on a deed and sold his house worth over Rs 30 lakh for merely Rs 16 lakh. All this while Manmeet had to never bother about the availability of the drug. "It's available in every street," he says.

Bathinda's Kanwar Kulbir Singh, 26, has been on smack for nearly four years now. Before that he used to take phensydyl and other cough syrups and medicines whose names he can't even recall now. His tryst with smack began in Chandigarh where he went for a job with a call centre. "I had rented a flat where friends would hang out and some of them were on smack. They would coax me to have a sniff and I couldn't offend them for long." Kanwar would often doze off at work, before he was fired. He went back to Bathinda, and drugs. "It is easy to get drugs in Bathinda but more so in Chandigarh. Just a call and it would be home-delivered," he says.

Drugs have taken over Punjab. Sixty-seven per cent of the rural households have at least one drug addict. Three out of 10 girls have abused one or the other drug. Of school-goers, 66 per cent chew gutka or tobacco. Seven out of 10 college-going students abuse some drug. The frightening figures feature in a recent affidavit filed by the Punjab Government in the Punjab and Haryana High Court. "We are in danger of losing the young gen-

High and DRY

From being the land of milk and honey, the state emerges as a transit point for narcotics smuggled from the Af-Pak region to the West

Bir Devinder Singh | PATIALA | 31

One-time sportsman who represented the nation in junior boxing, now punches the air in vain.

"My hands tremble and body wobbles due to the decade-old drug addiction."



AT THE CHETNA FOUNDATION DRUG COUNSELLING AND REHABILITATION CENTRE IN ZIRAKPUR

Manmeet Singh | PATIALA | 24

The vibrant young man went off tangent and even sold off his parents' house for peanuts.

"Initially I could manage it from home. Then I began to borrow, beg and even steal. Soon I was in debt."



67% of rural households have at least one drug addict

70% of college-goers abuse one or the other drug

eration," says Harjit Singh, secretary, Department of Social Security and Women and Child Development. It has set alarm bells ringing.

The scene is particularly bad in rural Punjab. Cut to a village in Moga. At over 40 degrees, it's unbearably hot and humid. In a corner of a huge

courtyard, Varinder Singh, 26, lies on a cot, almost unconscious, his face all sweaty yet covered with a bedsheet. It takes a lot of effort for his family to even wake him up. "My body's been aching since last night," he says. But a family member says this is routine since he started taking morphine in-